



MCU delay affects Sony releases
The delay of MCU films, including the new Spider-Man film, caused Sony to delay Spider-Verse films too. <https://digit.in/may20-19>



Fortnite concert drew in millions
Travis Scott's in-game concert brought a record 12.3 million concurrent players to Fortnite. <https://digit.in/may20-20>

Storytelling through Aspect Ratio

Choosing the right aspect ratio is integral

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When watching a movie, there are several aspects that attract the viewer. These include things such as a compelling story, actors and music. Some are even drawn to a certain director's work. One thing that most people seem to miss, or rather not pay heed to, is the film's aspect ratio. Whether it is watching on a phone, or a television or a movie theatre, aspect ratio plays a significant role in delivery. An aspect ratio is nothing but the proportional relationship between the height and width of the image that is seen on screen. It basically refers to the size of the image being displayed on the screen. Choosing the right aspect ratio from a pool of available options, allows directors to add a layer of deeper meaning and storytelling to their movies. When done right, it can have a significant impact on the story and attracting the audience.

Back in the day, most films followed a boxy aspect ratio. They were shot in a 1.37:1 ratio. Also known as the Academy Ratio. Most modern films follow a widescreen aspect ratio to tell their story. With the advancements in technology in the world of filmmaking over the years, they now have the option to film in any aspect ratio of their choice. Preferences in aspect ratios are subjective. Some filmmakers choose an aspect ratio

based on the time period the story is set in or the feeling they want to convey to the audience. While other directors choose an aspect ratio they like and stick with it throughout their careers. For example, David Fincher, the director of movies like Fight Club, Seven and Gone Girl only films in a 2.35:1 aspect ratio. It assists in incorporating his sleek cinematography with wide environments. On the flip side of the coin, Andrea Arnold, the



A still from *The Lighthouse* showing the cramped aspect ratio and environment

director of movies like Red Road and American Honey, prefers older boxier formats to create the effect of loneliness and claustrophobia. Most indie movies nowadays, follow the custom of weird aspect ratios to garner attraction towards their work. Some filmmakers even implement multiple aspect ratios into one. Let us take a look at some of these artsy movies to understand how aspect ratios impacted their storytelling.

THE LIGHTHOUSE (2019)

Directed by Robert Eggers, *The Lighthouse* follows the story of two lighthouse keepers on a remote island, somewhere near New England. It is a psychological horror story set in the 1980s. The film focuses on the

characters' gradual descent into madness, due to confinement during the harsh stormy weather. Other than the black and white colour palette, the film follows a boxy aspect ratio. The entire film was shot in a 1.19:1 aspect ratio. This was done not just to create the look and feel of a vintage film, but also to contribute to the feeling of confinement. Since it is the story of two lighthouse keepers in close proximity, there were hints of intimacy and claustrophobia throughout. Throughout the film, the characters would want to keep themselves away from each other as much as possible. This is due to the damp, musky environment surrounding them and the fact that they could not stand each other's existence. However, they are unable to, since they are stuck on a tiny island with nowhere to go. This gradual development of insanity and cabin fever is reflected onto the audience through the cinematography and the tiny frame within which the actors are confined. The movement is limited and there is no space to escape. Since the aspect ratio had already been decided, the sets had to be built from scratch to accommodate it as well. Other than the story, the director attempts to convey to the audience the effects long-term confinement could have. Be it with a loved one, or someone you despise.



A still from *A Ghost Story* highlighting entrapment